

Figure 1: The gnotime time tracking utility

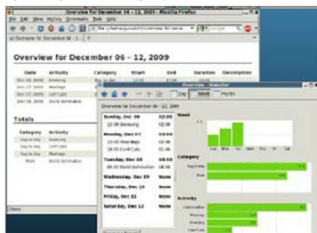


Figure 2: Hamster time tracking solution

with his manager and discussed how he wanted to use a capable time-tracking tool in the project to gather actionable data. "Gnotime has multiple timers (though only one is active at a time) and supports a hierarchical task structure to roll up task durations. Time tracking happens at three levels for an activity: the total time spent, the time spent that day, and the time spent on a particular journal entry. It has a large set of predefined reports and you can create your own reports, too," explained Amol.

The afternoon was spent with Amol and his manager chalking out a plan on how to deploy Gnotime in the project. They discussed how Gnotime could be used to generate notional invoices for project effort -- for billing or budgeting purposes. The tool also had a customisable inactivity timeout feature to prevent erroneous crediting of time when someone is away from the keyboard. The tool could also be used as a project journal with time stamping or a to-do list tracker, among other things. It could even be used as a mini task planner by utilising the 'Planning Tab' on the 'Properties' dialogue box. The only confusing aspect they found was that Gnotime used the terms 'Project' and 'Task' rather interchangeably, and it was important to be aware of this.

Deploying Gnotime

The duo wisely decided not to unleash all the capabilities of Gnotime on the team. While tracking personal project time would be done by individual contributors, consolidation of data would happen at the module leader level. The company had been trying to standardise activity heads for billing purposes. This, along with the standard WBS codes for his project, helped Amol keep the time tracking practice uniform and consistent across his project. The project manager would have the individual time journals available while updating his project plan and during project reviews.

Any metrics data, including time sheet data, needs to be used to target the process and not the people. This is a very fine distinction, and if overlooked, has the potential of upsetting some people. Amol decided to call in his manager to moderate the next few project meetings in which time tracking reports were discussed at length. The Quality Coordinator was very eager to help analyse the data. The project was successful in identifying the systemic and project-related root causes that were a drain on time.

With a time tracking and management discipline in place, the project not only began to deliver results but also kept the team members motivated enough to stay on longer, without opting out.

And Amol also found out the answer to the following question...

How does a project get late?

It was Friday evening and Amol was heading to the coffee machine for what was positively the last mug of the dark brew. "Gnotime is a great tool for projects; is there a tool to track personal time?" That was from the head of *Products*. Clearly the Albatross' flight had been noticed.

"Sure," said Amol. "Have you tried Hamster? It is a GNOME desktop applet and helps you track time under various heads with a report generation facility. It is a great tool for personal time management."

So, how indeed does a project get late? "One day at a time!" I told you it was not a trick question. 

Resources

- http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Fred_Brooks is a good starting point to learn about Fred Brooks and his insights.
- The official Gnotime site: <http://gtr.sourceforge.net>

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